

Pulse360 Platform Frequently Asked Questions

HR performance, employee feedback, operational adoption, and people insight

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Purpose. This FAQ explains what Pulse360 does, who uses it, how the review workflow operates, what each role can access, what organizations need to provide, and how the platform uses analytics and AI. It is written for HR teams, Operations teams, stakeholders, people managers, employees, and support or RAG applications.

Knowledge use. Answers are intentionally structured as short question-and-answer units so they can be indexed separately. Pricing is a planning reference and can be updated without changing the platform capability descriptions.

1 Platform Overview

What is Pulse360?

Pulse360 is a role-based HR performance and employee contribution platform. It helps organizations run structured 360-degree review cycles, improve hiring and development decisions, recognize employee contributions, understand capability, and connect skills to organizational initiatives.

What business problems does Pulse360 address?

Pulse360 is designed to make people and performance processes more consistent and useful. It supports better hiring and internal mobility decisions, clearer performance conversations, recognition of contributions, employee development, and stronger adoption of internal tools and initiatives.

Who is Pulse360 for?

Pulse360 supports four connected audiences:

- HR teams manage employees, review cycles, criteria, approvals, analytics, demographics, and reports.
- Operations teams monitor workflow health, platform adoption, manager accountability, and improvement opportunities.
- People managers approve team nominations, track review progress, identify bottlenecks, and view team results.
- Stakeholders receive high-level workforce, contribution, adoption, and organizational health signals without access to sensitive individual review content.

Is Pulse360 an HR system of record?

Pulse360 is a performance and people-insight application. It can hold the employee attributes needed for its workflows, but it should not automatically replace a payroll, benefits, identity, or core HR system unless an approved integration is designed and governed.

2 Roles and Access

What can an HR Admin do?

HR Admins operate the people and review process. They can create, edit, and delete employees; manage departments and manager mappings; reset passwords for newly added or new-hire users; change roles for

promotions or organizational changes; create and manage review cycles; configure criteria; manage nominations and approvals; view detailed HR analytics; and generate reports.

What can a Line Manager do?

Line Managers can approve nominations for their direct reports, complete their own assigned reviews, monitor team review progress, identify outstanding work, and view team results according to the cycle phase and their permissions.

What can an Employee do?

Employees can maintain permitted profile details, nominate peers during the nomination phase, view their assigned review tasks, submit feedback for approved assignments, use optional AI assistance, view released personal results, and access development or self-improvement tools.

What can a System Admin do?

The System Admin is a separate IT-oriented monitoring role, not an HR Admin. System Admin access is intended for aggregated audit, platform adoption, operational, and AI-usage analytics. System Admins should not see sensitive review comments or individual review scores.

Can HR and Operations see the same dashboard?

They should not receive identical views. HR needs deeper people, performance, demographic, development, and retention context. Operations needs workflow, adoption, approval health, manager workload, and internal-tool improvement signals. Stakeholders should receive summarized organizational indicators.

How is access controlled?

Access is role-based and should be enforced on both the user interface and server-side APIs. A hidden navigation item is not a security control. Every sensitive query and mutation must verify the signed-in identity, role, organization scope, and permitted entity scope.

3 Review Cycle Workflow

What are the review cycle phases?

A typical cycle moves through Draft, Nominate, Approve, Review, Consultation, Accept, and Closed. The exact labels and transition rules can be configured in the application, but each phase should have a clear purpose and a controlled transition.

Phase	Purpose	Primary users
Draft	Configure dates, description, criteria, questions, and rules.	HR Admin
Nominate	Employees submit peer nominations.	Employees, HR
Approve	Line managers and authorized HR users approve or reject nominations.	Managers, HR
Review	Approved reviewers submit structured feedback.	Employees, managers
Consultation	Managers review team results privately before release.	Managers, HR
Accept	Results are released to employees according to policy.	HR, employees
Closed	The cycle becomes a historical record.	HR, stakeholders

Can a cycle have a description?

Yes. HR Admins can add a short description explaining the purpose, focus, or scope of the review cycle. This helps employees understand why the cycle exists and what the organization wants to learn.

How do nominations, approvals, and reviews connect?

An employee nominates reviewers. The relevant line manager or authorized HR user approves or rejects those nominations. Once approved, the reviewer receives a review assignment. A reviewer can submit feedback only for an approved assignment, subject to the current cycle phase and access rules.

What happens when a line manager approves a nomination?

The nomination status changes from pending to approved, the approval is recorded in the audit trail, and the approved reviewer can become eligible to complete the review. Counters and notifications should update in the current browser session without requiring a full page refresh.

What happens when an employee nominates someone?

The nomination is stored against the employee and cycle, then routed for approval. Once the line manager approves the nomination and the review phase opens, the nominee can complete the required review assignment. The platform should prevent unapproved or out-of-phase review submissions.

How should manager mappings work?

A line manager should be linked to the employee record through an explicit manager relationship. Approval workload and team progress should be calculated from that relationship, not inferred from department names or job titles. HR should be able to correct mappings when organizational structures change.

4 Employee Profile and Organization Data

What employee information can Pulse360 store?

The employee profile can include name, email, password or authentication reference, role, department, job title, job grade, line manager, active status, employment type, conversion-hire status, gender, and ethnicity where the organization has a lawful and trusted reason to collect them.

Which employment types can be supported?

The platform can support Permanent, Contract, Internship, Learnership, and other organization-approved categories. Employment type should be an explicit field, not inferred permanently from a title, because a person's employment arrangement can change.

What is conversion-hire status?

Conversion-hire status can represent Yes, No, Pending Decision, and Reviewed. It is useful for tracking whether an intern, learner, or contractor may be considered for permanent employment, but it should be governed as an HR field with clear ownership and update history.

Can gender include an Other option?

Yes. Gender can include Male, Female, Other, and an optional Not disclosed value where appropriate. Demographic fields should be voluntary where required by policy, protected by role-based access, and reported in aggregated form when used for analytics.

How should ethnicity data be handled?

An organization may configure categories such as Black, White, Coloured, Asian, and Indian where these categories are appropriate to its legal and organizational context. Ethnicity should be visible only to authorized HR users and used for aggregate inclusion reporting, not individual performance decisions without proper governance.

Can HR edit employee details?

Yes. HR Admins should be able to edit permitted employee details and correct department, role, grade, employment, gender, manager, and status data. Profile changes should create an audit event showing who changed the record, what changed, and when.

Can employees edit their own details?

Employees can be allowed to edit low-risk personal details according to organizational policy. Sensitive fields such as role, department, grade, employment type, manager, and access role should remain HR-controlled or require an approval workflow.

Can employees be imported in bulk?

Yes. The onboarding process is intended to support bulk employee import from an approved CSV, followed by validation of departments, roles, job grades, employment types, and manager mappings. Manual entry remains available for small corrections or individual additions.

5 Dashboards and Analytics

What should an Employee see at a glance?

The employee dashboard should prioritize current actions: nominations still in draft, reviews awaiting submission, current cycle phase, submitted reviews, manager context, and a direct path to released results. Detailed scores and multi-cycle performance trends belong on My Results to avoid duplicated information.

What should a Line Manager see at a glance?

The manager dashboard should show approval workload, team review completion, personal review assignments, team size, bottlenecks, and a compact performance snapshot. Detailed team results should remain on Team Results.

What should an HR Admin see at a glance?

The HR dashboard should show cycle status, nomination and review completion, approval health, participation gaps, employee coverage, manager mapping issues, demographic distributions, talent signals, and quick actions such as creating a cycle, importing employees, and generating reports.

What should stakeholders see?

Stakeholders should see high-level trends such as participation, completion, workforce capability, cross-department collaboration, platform adoption, and retention or development indicators where available. Individual comments and sensitive scores should remain outside this view unless explicitly governed.

How does My Results handle multiple cycles?

If an employee has results for one released cycle, the page shows that cycle without an unnecessary toggle. If results exist for multiple released cycles, the employee can switch between cycles and view a broader first-to-latest performance trend. Only released cycles should be included.

What is a bottleneck?

A bottleneck is an actionable delay in the workflow, such as pending manager approvals, incomplete review assignments, teams with low participation, or employees without valid manager mappings. Bottleneck cards should link directly to the relevant work queue.

Should dashboard data refresh automatically?

Yes. Dashboard counters and workflow states should refresh without a full page reload. A practical first implementation is an authenticated no-store data endpoint polled on a short interval and refreshed when the browser regains focus. Mutation responses should also update the local state immediately when possible.

6 Audit Trail and System Monitoring

What should be audited?

Audit events should capture important platform transactions and interactions, including logins, login failures, profile changes, role changes, manager or department changes, nominations, approvals, rejections, review submissions, report generation, AI generation, AI decisions, and governance changes.

What is the System Admin dashboard for?

The System Admin dashboard is for monitoring platform health and behavior, not evaluating the substance of individual reviews. It can show adoption, operational throughput, aggregate workflow health, AI usage metadata, token totals, and recent governance events.

What should System Admin analytics avoid?

System Admin analytics should avoid exposing review comments, individual scores, or a direct map of who nominated whom. Sensitive information should be aggregated or anonymized to protect trust in the 360-degree process.

Which AI usage data can be monitored?

The platform can monitor how many employees use AI generation, how many write without AI, input and output token totals, generation success or failure, and whether AI output was accepted, edited, or discarded. Token data is operational metadata and should be reported in aggregate where possible.

How should audit data be structured?

A scalable design separates immutable event records from query-friendly dimensions and facts. Authentication events, profile events, nomination events, review events, AI usage events, and AI decision events can hold

domain-specific details, while a general audit log can provide a common governance index. This supports efficient dashboards without making one table carry every data shape.

7 AI Capabilities

What does AI do in Pulse360?

AI is an optional assistant for drafting or summarizing content. Current use cases include suggested review comments, theme summaries, improvement plans, and narrative reports. AI output is intended to support human judgment, not replace it.

Can an employee write a review without AI?

Yes. AI assistance should be optional. Employees can write their own feedback, use AI to generate a draft, edit the draft, accept it, or discard it. These choices can be recorded as anonymized AI interaction metadata for platform adoption analysis.

Can HR edit an AI-generated report before saving it?

Yes. HR should be able to review and edit the generated narrative before saving or downloading the final report. The saved report should represent the approved final version, with generation and editing activity recorded in the audit trail.

What safeguards are needed for AI?

AI features should include clear human review, role-appropriate access, input minimization, error handling, usage logging, token monitoring, and clear labeling that generated content may require correction. Sensitive comments should not be exposed to unauthorized analytics roles.

8 Reporting and Downloads

What can HR report on?

HR can generate executive-style reports containing cycle information, participation, completion, department summaries, criteria patterns, and approved narrative insights. Report content should respect role permissions and the selected cycle or date range.

Should reports download as PDF or HTML?

The intended user experience is a browser download of a PDF report, not a file-path message pointing to an HTML file. The report should include the narrative, analytics charts, visual dashboards, cycle context, and the final reviewed content.

Where should a downloaded file be saved?

The browser should trigger a standard download so the user's operating system chooses its configured Downloads folder. The application should not display or hard-code a developer's local path such as C:\Users\...\Downloads.

How should CSV downloads work?

CSV exports should be generated in the browser or returned as a downloadable response with a Content-Disposition attachment filename. The user should receive a file download regardless of their operating system or local username. The application should not assume a Windows path.

9 Requirements and Technical Architecture

What technology stack does Pulse360 use?

The current platform uses TypeScript, Node.js, Next.js, React, PostgreSQL, Supabase PostgreSQL, Prisma ORM, NextAuth.js, Tailwind CSS, GitHub, GitHub Actions, Render, and OpenAI API integration.

What does an organization need to use Pulse360?

An organization needs an active web service, a PostgreSQL-compatible database, a configured authentication secret, a canonical application URL, and role-appropriate environment variables. If AI features are enabled, the organization also needs an OpenAI API key configured outside source control.

What database architecture is recommended?

PostgreSQL should remain the transactional system of record for employees, cycles, nominations, approvals, reviews, and results. Supabase can host the operational PostgreSQL database. A separate analytics warehouse such as BigQuery is better suited to aggregate event analysis and scheduled reporting rather than replacing the transactional database.

How should deployments handle database migrations?

Build steps should generate the Prisma client, while production migrations should run through a controlled deployment command against the configured database. Migration files must use clean UTF-8 text without a byte-order mark that PostgreSQL cannot parse. Failed migrations require recovery or resolution before new migrations can be applied.

How should CI/CD work?

Changes should be committed to a feature branch, validated by GitHub Actions, reviewed through a pull request, merged into the protected main branch, and then deployed by Render. Required checks and branch rules should reference the exact workflow status name produced by the current CI configuration.

What environment variables are important?

Typical variables include DATABASE_URL, NEXTAUTH_SECRET, NEXTAUTH_URL, NODE_ENV, and any AI provider key. NEXTAUTH_URL must be the deployed public base URL with no trailing slash, for example <https://pulse360-gkt8.onrender.com>. Secrets must be configured in the hosting provider and never committed to Git.

10 Pricing and Capability Tiers

The following tiers are planning definitions for the public homepage and may be revised. Employee limits refer to active employees. Final pricing, billing terms, taxes, exchange rates, and included features should be confirmed before commercial publication.

Tier	Employee range	Planning capabilities
Free	Up to 59	Core review cycles, nominations, approvals, and basic results and reports.
Basic	60 to 149	Historical analytics, PDF reports and exports, and advanced AI add-ons.
Premium	150 to 499	Advanced HR and Operations analytics, expanded AI and reporting, and priority support.
Enterprise	500+	Custom integrations, governance, support, implementation guidance, and negotiated terms.

How does annual pricing work?

Annual pricing is calculated as the monthly fee multiplied by 12, with a 15 percent discount applied to the total. For example, Basic at 49 dollars per month is $49 \times 12 \times 0.85 = 499.80$ dollars per year before any currency conversion or tax.

Can prices display in local currency?

The public mock can infer a region from the browser timezone and display a configured currency such as ZAR for South Africa. Production billing should use a controlled currency and exchange-rate policy, not an unverified client-side conversion alone.

11 Security, Privacy, and Governance

How is sensitive review content protected?

Access to review comments and scores should be limited by role, cycle phase, employee relationship, and organizational policy. System Admin and stakeholder views should use aggregated or anonymized information. API routes must enforce these rules server-side.

Is personal data used for analytics?

Only data necessary for the stated HR, operational, or platform-adoption purpose should be used. Demographic reporting should be aggregated, access-controlled, and governed according to applicable law and organizational policy.

How are changes traceable?

Important changes should create immutable audit events containing actor, action, entity type, entity identifier where appropriate, metadata, and timestamp. Domain event tables can provide more detailed records for authentication, profiles, nominations, reviews, and AI interactions.

What should happen when an employee leaves?

HR should be able to deactivate the employee while preserving historical records required for reporting and governance. Access should be revoked, the employee should no longer count toward active employee limits, and historical results should remain subject to retention policy.

12 Troubleshooting and Support

Why does a dashboard counter appear stale?

The page may be displaying server-rendered data from the initial request. The recommended fix is an authenticated no-store endpoint plus client-side polling, focus refresh, and immediate local updates after a successful mutation. The UI should show a small live or updating state so users know when data was last checked.

Why can a deployment build successfully but fail during startup?

Build success and runtime success are separate checks. A service can compile successfully and still fail when it cannot reach the database, when Prisma migrations fail, when an environment variable is incorrect, or when the start command exits. Inspect the first runtime error after the start command.

What does Prisma P3009 mean?

P3009 means the target database contains a failed migration, so Prisma will not apply later migrations. The failed migration must be investigated and recovered or marked resolved using the correct production procedure before redeploying.

What does Prisma P3018 mean?

P3018 means a migration failed to apply. Check the underlying database error. A common PostgreSQL cause is invalid SQL text, including an unexpected UTF-8 byte-order mark at the beginning of a migration file. Correct the migration and recover the database migration state before retrying.

What does Prisma P1001 mean?

P1001 means Prisma cannot reach the database server. Check that DATABASE_URL points to the intended active database, that the hostname and port are correct, that the provider allows the connection, and that the service is not using an expired or suspended database.

What is the support checklist for a failed deployment?

Record the deployment time, commit, service, build result, start command, first database or application error, environment changes, attempted fix, verification result, and remaining risk. Keep the record in the project audit trail so the next investigation starts from evidence rather than memory.

13 RAG Retrieval Notes

Recommended metadata for indexing this document:

- product: Pulse360
- document_type: platform_faq
- audiences: HR, Operations, stakeholders, people_managers, employees, system_admin
- topics: workflows, dashboards, analytics, AI, privacy, reporting, pricing, deployment, troubleshooting
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Retrieval guidance. Preserve the question and answer together when chunking. Prefer one section or question-answer unit per chunk. Keep the pricing section independently replaceable. Do not index credentials, API keys, passwords, or private employee records with this public FAQ.

14 Glossary

Term	Meaning
360-degree review	Structured feedback collected from multiple perspectives, such as peers, managers, and self-assessment.
Cycle	A defined period and workflow for nominations, approvals, reviews, results, and closure.
Nomination	A proposal that a person should review another employee in a specific cycle.
Approval	A decision that allows a nomination to become an eligible review assignment.
Review result	A calculated score or criterion-level outcome created from submitted feedback.
Platform adoption	How consistently users access and use the platform's workflows and features.
System Admin	A monitoring role focused on aggregate platform operations and governance rather than HR content.
RAG	Retrieval-augmented generation, where a chatbot retrieves trusted source passages before generating an answer.